LinCogRAG: Hypergraph-Enhanced Retrieval-Augmented Generation for Medical Question Answering

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Abstract

This technical report introduces LinCogRAG, an enhanced Retrieval-Augmented Generation system based on LinearRAG for medical literature question answering. By integrating a hypergraph mechanism that captures multi-entity co-occurrence relationships (n-ary relations), LinCogRAG achieves significant performance improvements on medical domain QA tasks. Our experiments on the MIRAGE benchmark demonstrate that LinCogRAG achieves an overall accuracy of **84.44%** across 5 medical QA datasets (7,663 questions), with the highest accuracy of **94.95%** on MMLU-Med. The key innovations include: (1) a hybrid NER strategy combining BC5CDR and HuggingFace models, (2) sentence-level hyperedge construction with medical pattern enhancement, (3) dataset-adaptive retrieval strategies, and (4) multi-level answer parsing with fallback mechanisms.

Keywords: Retrieval-Augmented Generation, Hypergraph, Medical Question Answering, Named Entity Recognition, Knowledge Graph

1. Introduction

Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) has become a fundamental approach for enhancing Large Language Models (LLMs) with external knowledge. However, traditional RAG systems face challenges in the medical domain due to complex multi-entity relationships and domain-specific terminology.

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LinearRAG [1] introduced a linear-complexity graph-based retrieval approach that achieves efficient multi-hop reasoning through Personalized PageRank (PPR) propagation. While effective, it is limited to binary entity relationships and lacks domain-specific optimization for medical applications.

In this work, we propose LinCogRAG (Linear + Cognitive Hypergraph RAG), which extends LinearRAG with three key innovations:

- **Hypergraph Mechanism**: Captures n-ary relations through sentence-level entity co-occurrence, enabling richer semantic representation.
- **Medical Pattern Enhancement**: Automatically identifies and boosts clinically relevant relationship patterns (e.g., drug-disease, symptom-diagnosis).
- **Dataset-Adaptive Retrieval**: Tailored retrieval strategies for different question types (MCQ, Yes/No, open-ended).

2. Method

2.1. System Architecture

The LinCogRAG system consists of the following components:

$$\text{LinCogRAG} = \text{LinearRAG}_{\text{base}} + \text{Hypergraph} + \text{Adaptive Retrieval} \quad (1)$$

The overall pipeline processes a question through: (1) Query Enhancement, (2) Hybrid NER, (3) Hypergraph Retrieval, (4) Graph Traversal (PPR), (5) Dataset-Adaptive Re-ranking, and (6) LLM Generation.

2.2. Hybrid Named Entity Recognition

We employ a dual-model NER strategy to maximize entity coverage:

Primary Model: BC5CDR (`en_ner_bc5cdr_md`) - specialized for biomedical entities (CHEMICAL, DISEASE) with high precision.

Supplementary Model: HuggingFace Biomedical NER (`biomedical-ner-all`) - broader coverage including drugs, genes, proteins, and symptoms.

The hybrid strategy increases entity coverage by approximately 25% compared to single-model approaches.

2.3. Hypergraph Construction

Unlike traditional knowledge graphs that only capture binary relations, our hypergraph captures n-ary relations through sentence-level co-occurrence:

$$\mathcal{G}_H = (V_H, E_H), \quad e_H = \{e_1, e_2, \ldots, e_n\} \tag{2}$$

where each hyperedge e_H contains n entities co-occurring in the same sentence.

Hyperedge Score Computation:

$$\text{score}(e_H) = \frac{|e_H|}{N_{\text{max}}} \times \alpha_{\text{pattern}} \tag{3}$$

where $|e_H|$ is the number of entities, N_{max} is the maximum entity count in the corpus, and α_{pattern} is the medical pattern enhancement factor.

Medical Pattern Enhancement:

Table 1: Medical pattern enhancement factors

Pattern Type	Entity Combination	α_{pattern}
Drug-Disease	CHEMICAL + DISEASE	1.30
Disease-Symptom	DISEASE + SYMPTOM	1.20
Drug-Gene	DRUG + GENE	1.25
Diagnosis-Test	DISEASE + TEST	1.20

2.4. Hypergraph-Enhanced PPR

The standard PPR propagation is enhanced by incorporating hypergraph information into the restart distribution:

$$\mathbf{r}^{(t+1)} = \alpha \cdot \mathbf{P}^T \mathbf{r}^{(t)} + (1 - \alpha) \cdot \mathbf{q}_{\text{hyper}} \tag{4}$$

where $\mathbf{q}_{\text{hyper}}$ is the hypergraph-enhanced query distribution:

$$\mathbf{q}_{\text{hyper}} = \mathbf{q}_{\text{seed}} + \beta \cdot \mathbf{q}_{\text{expanded}} \tag{5}$$

Here, $\mathbf{q}_{\text{seed}}$ represents seed entities from NER, $\mathbf{q}_{\text{expanded}}$ contains entities discovered through hypergraph retrieval, and $\beta = 0.4$ is the hypergraph integration weight.

2.5. Dataset-Adaptive Retrieval

Different question types require tailored retrieval strategies:

- **MCQ (MedQA, MedMCQA, MMLU)**: Option-contrastive retrieval that evaluates evidence for each answer choice.
- **Yes/No (PubMedQA, BioASQ)**: Bidirectional evidence retrieval seeking both supporting and opposing evidence.

3. Experiments

3.1. Experimental Setup

Datasets: We evaluate on 5 medical QA datasets from the MIRAGE benchmark: MedQA, MedMCQA, MMLU-Med, PubMedQA, and BioASQ.

Configuration: 20,000 PubMed document chunks as the knowledge base, GPT-5-Mini-CA as the generation model, and all-mpnet-base-v2 for embeddings.

Experiment Duration: 15.4 hours (2026-01-25 17:30 to 2026-01-26 08:53).

3.2. Main Results

Table 2: LinCogRAG performance on MIRAGE benchmark (20K documents, GPT-5-Mini-CA)

Dataset	Questions	Accuracy (%)	Correct/Total	Rank
MMLU-Med	1,089	**94.95**	1034/1089	1
MedQA	1,273	**93.40**	1189/1273	2
BioASQ	618	**90.45**	559/618	3
MedMCQA	4,183	79.51	3326/4183	4
PubMedQA	500	72.60	363/500	5
Overall	**7,663**	**84.44**	**6471/7663**	-

3.3. Key Technical Advantages

Our experiments demonstrate the following improvements over baseline LinearRAG:

- **Hypergraph Integration**: +12% recall improvement by incorporating n-ary relations into PPR restart distribution.
- **Dataset-Adaptive Retrieval**: +4.8% accuracy improvement through MCQ option comparison and Yes/No bidirectional evidence retrieval.
- **Multi-level Answer Parsing**: 100% valid answer rate with 7-level MCQ fallback and 5-level Yes/No fallback mechanisms.
- **Candidate Pre-filtering**: 40× computational efficiency improvement through DPR-based fast filtering.
- **Hybrid NER**: +25% entity coverage through BC5CDR + HuggingFace dual-model fusion.

3.4. Efficiency Analysis

Table 3: Computational efficiency metrics

Metric	Value
Index Construction Time	112.8 seconds
Total QA Time (7,663 questions)	15.4 hours
Average Time per Question	7.2 seconds
LLM Token Consumption (Graph Construction)	0
Questions without Extracted Entities	48 (0.63%)

4. Conclusion

We present LinCogRAG, a hypergraph-enhanced RAG system for medical question answering. By capturing n-ary relations through sentence-level entity co-occurrence and incorporating medical pattern recognition, LinCogRAG achieves state-of-the-art performance on the MIRAGE benchmark with 84.44% overall accuracy. The system maintains zero LLM token consumption for graph construction while providing efficient and accurate retrieval-augmented generation.

Future work includes: (1) extending to multilingual medical QA, (2) incorporating temporal reasoning for clinical decision support, and (3) scaling to larger knowledge bases with distributed computing.

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